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FUNDRAISING



From idea to first check:
Raising pre-seed and
seed capital with Charles
Hudson and Navin
Chaddha at TechCrunch
Disrupt 2025



More than 10,000 founders, investors, and tech insiders will convene at Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27-29 for [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — one of the year's most anticipated tech conferences.

[Of the 250+ tech leaders taking the stage](#), don't miss this standout panel on the Builders Stage featuring two of the most respected early-stage investors in venture: [Charles Hudson](#) of Precursor Ventures and [Navin Chaddha](#) of Mayfield. Their session dives into one of the toughest moments in any startup's journey: raising your first round when all you have is a vision.

IMAGE CREDITS:

KIMBERLY WHITE / GETTY IMAGES

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October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

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Why join this conversation on the Builders Stage?

[This honest and tactical conversation](#) will cover what really matters when raising your first institutional check, from telling a compelling story

to building trust without traction. Hudson and Chaddha will share the traits they consistently look for in zero-to-one founders, the red flags that raise eyebrows, and the most common mistakes first-time entrepreneurs make when fundraising.

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

Betting on people before the product

Pre-seed and seed fundraising often happens before there's a product, user base, or traction. That means investors are betting on the founder, not the business. And few know how to make that call better than Hudson and Chaddha. Between them, they've backed hundreds of founders at the earliest stages, before the pitch decks were polished, before there were metrics to show, and often before a single line of code had shipped.



IMAGE CREDITS:HAJE KAMPS / TECHCRUNCH

Charles Hudson, managing partner of [Precursor Ventures](#), has invested in more than 400 companies and supported over 450 founders. He's built his reputation on backing people with bold ideas and unique perspectives, saying recently, "The earlier you invest, the more important it is to believe in the founder's narrative and ability to

adapt. It's not just about solving a problem — it's about whether I believe you're the one to do it.”

Navin Chaddha, managing partner at [Mayfield](#), brings decades of experience identifying breakout founders and guiding companies to scale. With more than \$120 billion in equity value created through his investments, Chaddha believes the earliest stages are when founder values matter most. “We invest in people first, markets second, and product third,” he’s said. “We look for founders who are mission-driven and wired for resilience.”

Actionable insights on raising your first round

Whether you're currently raising or planning for the future, this session will equip you with real, actionable advice on navigating early venture with clarity and conviction. Don't miss it live, in addition to [200+ sessions](#) taking place across five industry stages. [Register now to save](#) up to \$675 before prices increase after July!

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Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

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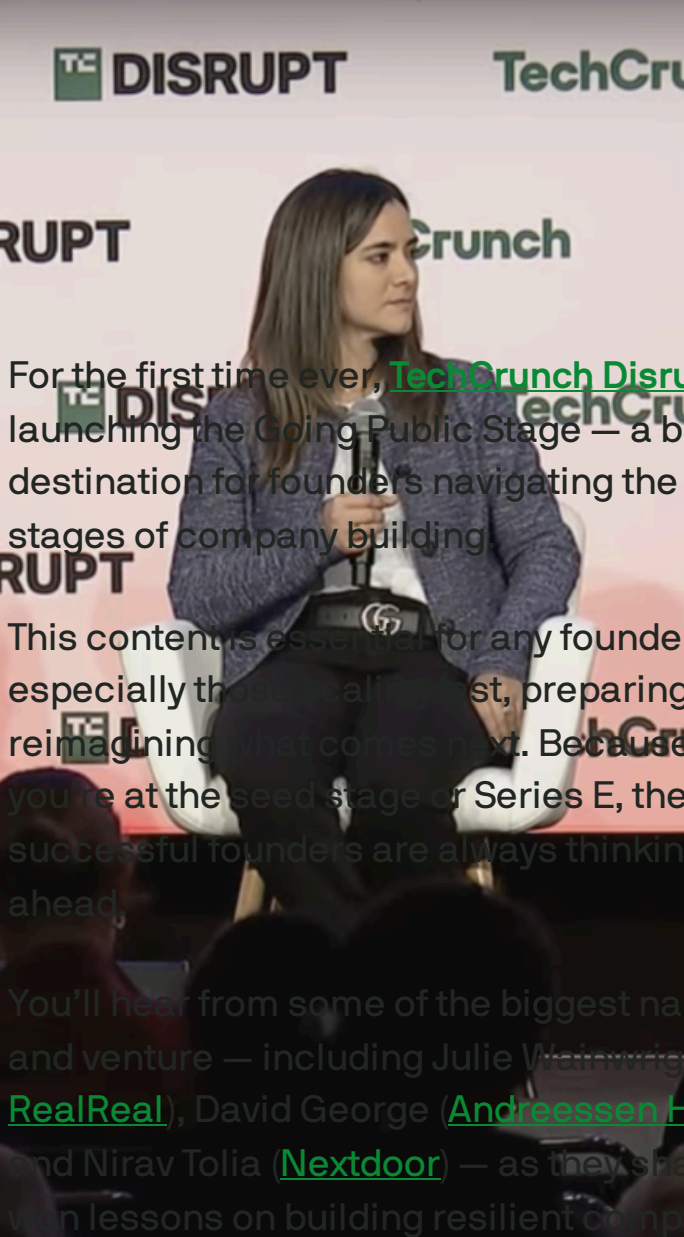
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VENTURE



Introducing the Going Public Stage at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025



For the first time ever, [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) is launching the Going Public Stage — a brand-new destination for founders navigating the mid and late stages of company building.

This content is essential for any founder, but especially those calling it a day, preparing for exit, or reimagining what comes next. Because whether you're at the seed stage or Series E, the most successful founders are always thinking 10 steps ahead.

You'll hear from some of the biggest names in tech and venture — including Julie Wainwright ([The RealReal](#)), David George ([Andreessen Horowitz](#)), and Nirav Tolia ([Nextdoor](#)) — as they share hard-learned lessons on building resilient companies, navigating shifting markets, and staying ahead of the curve.

From IPO prep to AI-powered GTM strategy, this stage is your roadmap for building what's next.

Stay tuned — more [sessions](#) and [speakers](#) are coming soon. In the meantime, mark the Going Public Stage as a can't-miss at Disrupt, and [grab your ticket now to save up to \\$675](#).

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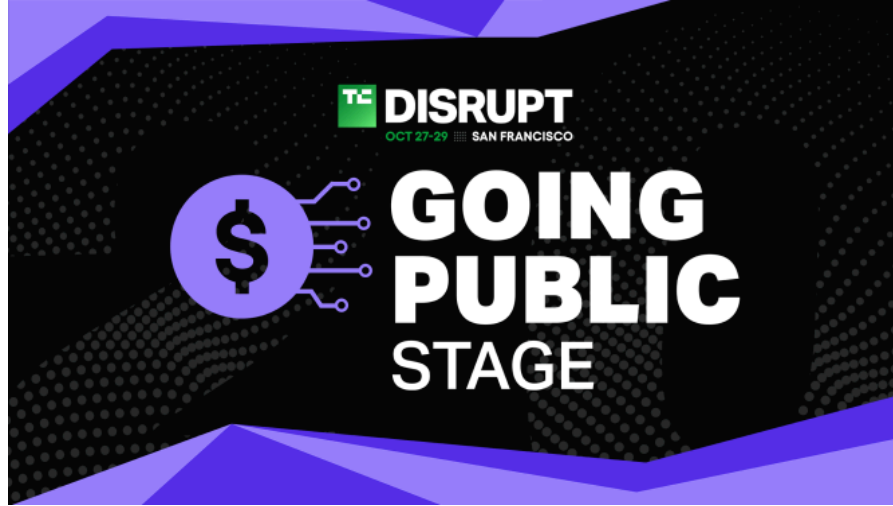


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How Long Should a Startup Stay Private?

[David George](#), general partner, Andreessen Horowitz

Startups today can grow to huge valuations, cash out their employees, and stay private longer than those of previous eras. But that also means that late-stage startups are facing a whole new set of rules. George unpacks the shifting VC landscape, what the next generation of scaled startups needs to know, and how capital is being deployed in an era of tighter money and higher expectations. From IPO windows to secondary markets to the evolving role of growth investors, this fireside chat goes deep on what it really takes to build enduring companies in today's market — and what's coming next.

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ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

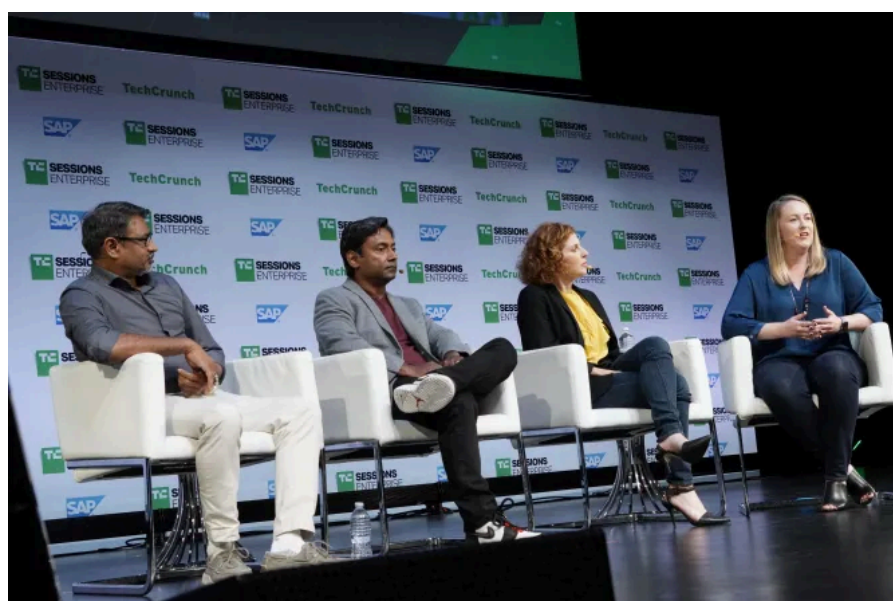
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Everything You Need to Know Before an Exit

[Jai Das](#), co-founder, president, and partner, Sapphire Ventures; [Roseanne Wincek](#), co-founder and managing director, Renegade Partners; and another speaker to be announced

Go public, get acquired, or double down and stay private? In today's unpredictable market, founders need to think about exit strategy earlier — and more strategically — than ever. This panel brings together two top VCs and a seasoned CFO to unpack how to set your company up for every option. We'll talk timing, metrics that matter, investor expectations, and what it really takes to navigate M&A, IPO prep, or just keep building through the storm. Whether you're 12 months out or just starting to scale, this conversation is all about making smart moves now for whatever comes next.



Building What Comes Next

Julie Wainwright, CEO, [Ahara](#); founder and former CEO, TheRealReal

Wainwright knows how to spot a wave — and ride it. From pioneering luxury resale at The RealReal to jumping into personalized nutrition with Ahara, she's made a career out of building ahead of the curve. In this fireside chat, Wainwright opens up about what it takes to start over, scale fast, and stay resilient through market shifts and personal pivots. We'll dig into the lessons learned from category creation, the risks of reinvention, and why experience might just be the ultimate startup edge.

How AI Is Forcing Late-stage Startups to Rewire GTM — or Be Left Behind

[Jane Alexander](#), partner, CapitalG; [Vanessa Larco](#), co-founder, Premise; and [Nirav Tolia](#), CEO, Nextdoor

AI is rewriting the playbook for how startups reach and win customers, and late-stage companies are feeling the pressure to adapt fast. In this panel, two top VCs and a seasoned founder break down how AI is transforming go-to-market strategies, from sales and marketing to customer success. We'll get into what's working, what's hype, and how to build AI into your GTM engine without losing focus. If you're scaling and wondering how AI fits into your next phase of growth, this is the conversation you don't want to miss.

Ready to exit? Start at Disrupt 2025

Whether you're weighing an acquisition, eyeing the IPO window, or mapping out your ideal exit, the [Going Public Stage at Disrupt 2025](#) is built for founders ready to make their next big move. Hear from leaders who've navigated the highs, the risks,

and the reinventions — and walk away with insights you can act on now.

Don't wait to sharpen your exit strategy. [Secure your pass to Disrupt 2025 and save up to \\$675](#) before prices rise. More sessions and speakers are coming soon, but this stage alone is worth the ticket.

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Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

TechCrunch Events — 6:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 marks 20 years of shaping the startup world, and tonight's your last chance to save up to \$675 on your ticket.

From October 27–29, Disrupt returns to Moscone West in San Francisco. Join 10,000+ tech innovators, founders, VCs, and ecosystem builders for three days of high-impact programming, networking, and startup energy.

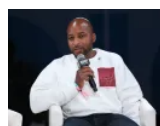
But first: your savings. You have until 11:59 p.m. PT tonight to save up to \$675. Once the clock strikes midnight, prices jump. [Register now.](#)

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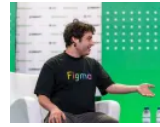


How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo

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TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

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- 20 hours ago

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Why you won't want to miss this 20th-anniversary Disrupt

TechCrunch Disrupt has been the launchpad for breakthroughs and next-generation deals for 20 years. It's not just another tech conference — it's where game-changing innovations are born, powerful connections are made, and ideas turn into action.

One session, one meeting, one moment — that's all it takes to change your trajectory. Disrupt is where startups break out, investors find the next big thing, and industry leaders stay ahead of the curve.

Featured Disrupt 2025 speakers

- Roelof Botha, [Sequoia Capital](#)
- Jeff Cardenas, [Apptronik](#)
- David George, [Andreessen Horowitz](#)
- Alex Kendall, [Wayve](#)
- Eunice Kim, [Netflix](#)
- Tekedra Mawakana, [Waymo](#)
- Alejandro Matamala Ortiz, [Runway](#)

- Ryan Petersen, [Flexport](#)
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- Astro Teller, [X](#), [The Moonshot Factory](#)
- Ethan Thornton, [Mach Industries](#)
- Nirav Tolia, [Nextdoor](#)
- Raquel Urtasun, [Waabi](#)
- Eric Yuan, [Zoom](#)
- Sangeen Zeb, [GV \(Google Ventures\)](#)
- ...and many more. New speakers are announced weekly. [Check the speaker page](#) often.



IMAGE CREDITS:HAJE KAMPS / TECHCRUNCH

Here's what's happening at Disrupt

Four Industry stages + the Disrupt Stage

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- **Going Public Stage:** Candid lessons from companies that made it

Interactive sessions

Join candid conversations with startup pros in small-group roundtables and breakout sessions. Ask real questions, get unfiltered answers, and gain in-depth insights not covered on the big stages.



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Startup Battlefield 200

Watch the top 20 TechCrunch–picked startups pitch live on the Disrupt Stage for a \$100,000 equity-free prize — with real-time VC feedback.

Explore what's next

Step into the Expo Hall and meet the startups creating tomorrow's tech. Founders: Want in? [Exhibit your startup](#) and get in front of investors, media, and future customers, before tables run out.

Make the right connections

Disrupt isn't about meeting *more* people — it's about meeting the *right* ones. Braindate helps you find those key conversations that move your goals forward, whether in a 1:1 or small-group format.

Additional benefits for investors and founders

The Deal Flow Café is where investors and founders connect over coffee to talk deals, raise rounds, and spark momentum.

In addition to access to the Deal Flow Café, Investor and Founder Pass holders unlock exclusive

benefits designed to make an impact:

- **Investors:** Enjoy a curated tour of the Expo Hall with formal introductions to startups that align with your investment focus. Plus, your reserved seat at the exclusive **StrictlyVC** session on Day 2 awaits.
- **Founders:** Get face time with investors actively scouting for their next big bet, whether you're raising now or building for what's next.



IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

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AI



Wonder Dynamics co-founder Nikola Todorovic joins the AI Stage at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 12:30 PM PDT · July 3, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:
DIEGO DONAMARIA/GETTY IMAGES FOR SXSW

[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) is back at Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27-29, bringing together 10,000+ startup and VC leaders to dig into what's next in tech. And when it comes to artificial intelligence, the conversations aren't just technical — they're creative, cinematic, and boundary-pushing. That's why [Nikola Todorovic](#) is headed to the AI Stage.

A visual effects veteran turned AI entrepreneur, Todorovic is the co-founder of [Wonder Dynamics](#), now an [Autodesk company](#). Alongside actor and producer Tye Sheridan, he helped launch Autodesk Flow Studio (formerly Wonder Studio), a groundbreaking AI platform that allows creators to seamlessly integrate 3D characters into live-action scenes. The platform uses cloud-based tools to automate complex processes like lighting, animation, and composition, giving filmmakers a radically faster and more accessible path to high-end visual effects.



Where film meets AI

Todorovic's journey to this moment wasn't traditional, but that's exactly the point. As an award-winning filmmaker and VFX supervisor, he spent years working at the intersection of storytelling and technology. That experience led to Wonder Dynamics, where the mission has always been to empower artists, not replace them. The

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- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

company's acquisition by Autodesk in 2024 marked a major validation of that vision, and now Todorovic is helping shape the future of creative AI inside one of the industry's biggest ecosystems.

At Disrupt, he'll join [other AI industry leaders](#) for a wide-ranging panel on what's coming next — from generative tools to ethical design to the future of creator workflows. Stay tuned to the fast-growing [Disrupt agenda page](#) for the latest updates. Expect a conversation in Todorovic's session that spans beyond buzzwords and dives into the real-world impact of AI in media and beyond.

Join 10,000 other tech and VC leaders on the AI Stage at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) to hear from Nikola Todorovic and other top voices driving the future of artificial intelligence. It's all happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Lock in your spot today and [save up to \\$675](#) before prices go up.

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